On-Call and Escalation Handbook

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Summary. Handbook for Northstar engineers who carry the pager. Explains the weekly on-call rotation, handover, paging acknowledgement and auto-escalation timings, compensation and compensatory off, rotation limits, swaps, leave, readiness and escalation paths.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This handbook explains how on-call duty works at Northstar Systems Private Limited: who is on call, how the rotation changes hands, what an on-call engineer must do when paged, how escalation works when a page is not answered, how on-call work is compensated and how engineers are protected from overload. It applies to all engineers and engineering managers who appear on a production service rotation for the Northstar Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect, Nexus Insight and their supporting infrastructure, and to Site Reliability Engineering (SRE) staff who maintain the rotation tooling.

The incident process itself (severity definitions, roles, status updates and post-incident reviews) is defined in ENG-004. Alert quality and runbook linking are defined in ENG-010. Customer-side support priorities and escalation are defined in CS-001. This handbook deals with the human side: the rota, the pager and the expectations around them.

2. Definitions

- **On-call engineer**: the engineer currently responsible for answering production pages for a service tier.
- **Primary and secondary**: each service tier has a primary on-call engineer who receives pages first and a secondary who receives the page if the primary does not acknowledge it.
- **Rotation**: the weekly schedule of who is primary and secondary for each tier.
- **Handover**: the formal transfer of on-call responsibility every Monday at 10:00 IST.
- **Page**: an automated alert delivered by phone call, push notification and SMS from the paging tool, triggered by NorthWatch for customer-impacting symptoms.
- **Night-time page**: a SEV1 or SEV2 page received between 22:00 and 06:00 IST.
- **Compensatory off (comp-off)**: a paid day off granted for qualifying night-time work.
- **Service tier**: Tier-1 (customer-facing, revenue critical), Tier-2 (internal critical), Tier-3 (non-critical).

- **Shadow**: a trainee who follows the primary for a week without being paged first.

3. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities
Primary on-call engineer	Acknowledges pages within 5 minutes, triages, declares incidents per ENG-004, acts as first responder
Secondary on-call engineer	Is reachable throughout the week, takes over when the primary does not acknowledge or asks for help
Engineering manager	Final automatic escalation point, owns the rota health for their team, approves swaps that break rules
Head of Site Reliability Engineering	Owns this handbook, the paging tool configuration and the quarterly on-call review
Engineering Director on call	Approves emergency changes and is the next escalation after the engineering manager
Security Desk	Receives suspected security incidents from the on-call engineer (ext. 5555)
HR Helpdesk	Answers questions about compensation and compensatory off recorded in NorthPeople and NorthPay

4. The Rotation

4.1 Weekly cycle

On-call runs on a weekly rotation. The handover happens every Monday at 10:00 IST. The outgoing primary must remain on call until the incoming primary confirms acknowledgement of the handover in the paging tool. If the handover time falls on a company holiday, the handover still occurs at 10:00 IST on that day unless the engineering manager publishes an alternative arrangement at least 3 business days earlier.

4.2 Primary and secondary per tier

Every service tier has a primary and a secondary engineer. Tier-1 services must have both roles staffed 24x7 in every week of the year. Tier-2 services also have a primary and a secondary during the SEV1 and SEV2 24x7 coverage described in ENG-004. Tier-3 services are covered in business hours by the owning team and are paged only if a Tier-1 or Tier-2 dependency is at risk.

4.3 Eligibility and training

An engineer may join a rotation after completing the following:

1 At least 8 weeks in the team and access to NorthWatch, NorthGate, NorthShip and the paging tool.
2 The on-call readiness course in NorthLearn.
3 One week as shadow to the current primary.
4 A tabletop simulated incident run by SRE.

Engineers in probation may shadow but must not be primary. Security Champions are preferred as secondary on services handling authentication or personal data, so that security-sensitive incidents have an informed reviewer.

4.4 Maximum load

No engineer may be on call for more than 1 week in 4. The rota planner must refuse to schedule an engineer in consecutive weeks, and an engineer who has served a primary week should not be secondary in the following week. This limit counts primary and secondary weeks together; teams that are too small to meet it must request additional engineers from adjacent teams through the engineering manager rather than breaching the limit.

5. Handover Procedure

The Monday handover consists of the following steps, which should take no more than 20 minutes.

1 The outgoing primary posts a written handover note in the team channel by Monday 09:30 IST: open incidents, active temporary mitigations, noisy alerts, planned changes in the coming week, known risks and any pending customer escalations.
2 The incoming primary reads the note and asks questions in the 10:00 handover call.
3 The incoming primary confirms in the paging tool that they are now primary, and the outgoing primary confirms they are off call.
4 The secondary receives the same note.
5 The rota is checked in the paging tool for the week, including holidays, planned leave and time zone settings (all schedules use IST).

If an incident is in progress at 10:00 IST on Monday, the outgoing primary stays in their role until the Incident Commander agrees a handover. The incoming primary joins as an observer and takes over when the IC releases the outgoing engineer.

6. Responding to a Page

6.1 Acknowledgement and escalation timing

The on-call engineer must acknowledge each page within 5 minutes. If the primary does not acknowledge within 5 minutes, the page automatically escalates to the secondary. If the secondary also does not acknowledge, the page escalates to the engineering manager after another 10 minutes. These timers run continuously and cannot be paused by the engineer.

Elapsed time since page	Who is paged
0 minutes	Primary on-call engineer
5 minutes (no acknowledgement)	Secondary on-call engineer
15 minutes (no acknowledgement from either)	Engineering manager

An acknowledgement means the engineer has seen the page and is starting work. It is not a promise of resolution. If the engineer cannot work on the issue (for example they are travelling or unwell), they must still acknowledge and immediately ask the secondary to take over in the team channel.

6.2 First ten minutes

After acknowledgement the engineer should:

1 Read the alert and open the runbook linked to it. An alert without a runbook link is a defect and must be reported to the service owner after the incident.
2 Check the golden signals dashboard in NorthWatch for the service.
3 Check NorthDesk and NorthShip for changes in the last 24 hours.
4 Decide on severity and declare an incident according to ENG-004 if customers are affected.

5 For SEV1 and SEV2, request an Incident Commander or accept the IC role if there is no one else trained.

6.3 Paging by humans

Support or Customer Success staff who believe a customer problem is production-wide should contact the on-call engineer through the paging tool "page engineer" action rather than by chat. A manual page is treated like an automated page and the same 5-minute acknowledgement applies.

6.4 Equipment and readiness

During a week on call the engineer must carry a company laptop with NorthTunnel, NorthID and NorthGate access working, have a charged phone with the paging app and reliable internet, and be able to reach a laptop within 15 minutes. The engineer must not travel to places without connectivity or perform activities that prevent acknowledgement. Working from a location other than the registered city is permitted while on call if connectivity and security requirements are met and the HR and Security approvals required for extended remote locations are in place.

7. Compensation and Compensatory Off

7.1 On-call allowance

An engineer who completes an on-call week as primary or secondary receives INR 2,000 per on-call week. The allowance is paid with the monthly payroll in NorthPay following the week in which the on-call duty ended, based on the rota record in the paging tool. A week that is cut short by less than half because of approved leave or a swap is paid pro-rata by the engineering manager's confirmation to the HR Helpdesk.

7.2 Compensatory off

In addition to the allowance, an engineer receives one compensatory off for each night-time (22:00 to 06:00 IST) SEV1 or SEV2 page lasting over 1 hour. The duration is measured from acknowledgement to the point at which the engineer is released by the Incident Commander. Compensatory off is recorded in NorthPeople by the engineering manager within 5 working days of the incident and must be used within 60 days.

Example: A primary engineer is paged at 23:40 IST for a SEV2, acknowledges in 3 minutes and is released by the IC at 01:05, a duration of 1 hour 22 minutes. This qualifies for one compensatory off. A second page the same night at 03:10 for a SEV1 that lasts 40 minutes does not qualify, because it lasted less than 1 hour. The engineer receives one compensatory off in total for the night, plus the weekly allowance.

Example: A SEV3 alert at 02:00 is acknowledged and fixed in 90 minutes. SEV3 pages do not qualify for compensatory off, and such pages should not wake engineers at night; the alert should be reclassified as non-paging.

7.3 Rest after incidents

An engineer who has worked more than 3 hours in a night-time incident should not be expected to join morning meetings and should start the next day late or take their compensatory off immediately. The engineering manager must make this practical by adjusting commitments.

7.4 Expenses

Reasonable expenses for connectivity (for example a hotspot during a power outage) may be claimed through NorthPay with receipts for any item above INR 500, within 15 calendar days of the expense date.

8. Swaps, Leave and Absence

- On-call swaps between two eligible engineers are allowed and should be recorded in the paging tool at least 2 business days before the swap, with the engineering manager informed.
- A swap must not create a violation of the 1-week-in-4 rule for either engineer. If it does, the engineering manager must approve in writing and record the reason in NorthDesk.
- Planned leave: an engineer who plans leave must notify the rota planner at least 10 working days ahead so the rota can be adjusted; for Earned Leave of 5 or more consecutive working days the leave notice rules in the HR policies already require 10 working days.
- Unplanned absence (sickness or emergency): the engineer informs the secondary and the engineering manager as soon as possible, and the secondary becomes primary until a replacement is found.
- An engineer on approved leave, sick leave or a company holiday must not be scheduled on call, except where they have chosen to swap into that week.
- Engineers who resign should be removed from the rota at the start of the notice period for Tier-1 services.

9. Escalation Paths

9.1 Engineering escalation

If the on-call engineer needs help, they should use the following sequence: the secondary on-call, the engineering manager, the Engineering Director on call, the VP Engineering. Emergency changes are approved by the Engineering Director on call. Security suspicion is reported to the Security Desk on ext. 5555 or at security@northstar-systems.example immediately, in parallel with engineering escalation.

9.2 Customer escalation

Customer escalations follow CS-001: Level 1 Support Engineer, Level 2 Support Lead, Level 3 Director of Customer Success or the Engineering on-call manager, Level 4 VP Customer Success and Level 5 CEO executive sponsor (Enterprise only). For P1 tickets, unresolved time triggers auto-escalation to Level 2 after 2 hours, Level 3 after 4 hours and Level 4 after 8 hours. The on-call engineer should expect to be asked for a technical update at each level and should provide it to the Communications Lead rather than direct to the customer.

9.3 When the escalation chain fails

If the engineering manager is also unreachable, the paging tool pages the Engineering Director on call. If no engineer in the chain can be reached for a SEV1, the Head of Site Reliability Engineering must be called by the Security Desk or IT Service Desk (ext. 4000), and the event is recorded as an on-call failure to be reviewed in the next quarterly review.

10. Quality of the On-Call Experience

10.1 Alert hygiene

Paging alerts must be customer-impacting symptoms with a runbook link, as defined in ENG-010. After each on-call week the primary must record, in the handover note, any page that required no action. A page that required no action twice in a month must be tuned or removed by the owning team within 10 business days.

10.2 Load review

SRE reviews on-call load every quarter: pages per shift, night-time pages, time to acknowledge, time to mitigate and the share of pages without runbooks. A rotation that averages more than 2 night-time SEV1 or SEV2 pages per on-call week for two consecutive quarters must be reviewed by the VP Engineering, who may add engineers, change service ownership or approve reliability work.

10.3 Wellbeing

Engineers may contact the Employee Assistance Programme, which offers a 24x7 counselling helpline with 3 free sessions per issue, if on-call work is causing stress. Managers should check in with the engineers coming off a heavy week.

11. Frequently Asked Questions

Can I be on call during my probation? You may shadow, but you must not be primary or secondary until probation is confirmed and the readiness steps in section 4.3 are done.

What happens if my phone dies and I miss a page? The page escalates to the secondary after 5 minutes and to the engineering manager after another 10 minutes. You must tell your manager what happened. Repeated misses are reviewed as an on-call failure and not as a disciplinary matter unless there is negligence.

Do I get paid if no page comes in? Yes. The INR 2,000 weekly allowance is paid for the week regardless of the number of pages.

Can I be on call two weeks in a row to clear a backlog? No. The limit is 1 on-call week in 4.

Who decides if a night-time page counts? The engineering manager checks the paging tool record and the NorthDesk incident ticket. The page must be SEV1 or SEV2, occur between 22:00 and 06:00 IST and last over 1 hour.

12. Related Documents

- ENG-004 Production Incident Management Procedure: severities, roles and PIR.
- ENG-010 Observability and Monitoring Standard: paging alert rules.
- CS-001 Customer Support Handbook: customer-facing escalation levels and notification rules.
- ENG-003 Software Deployment Runbook: emergency change approvals.

13. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
4.0	2025-01-14	Introduced 1-in-4 weekly load limit and readiness course
4.1	2025-05-02	Updated compensatory off rule for night-time pages
4.2	2025-08-05	Clarified escalation timings and swap rules